



USER GUIDE

Judge Guide

Authoring and running a competition on Flagpost

For **Judges & organisers** · Flagpost **1.4.0-src** · 23 August 2026

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The judge role

A judge is **competition-scoped staff**: everything in this guide applies to the competition(s) you help organise, granted through your role there. Site-wide concerns — user accounts, sign-in options, branding — belong to administrators (they have their own guide).

What Flagpost’s permissions give you that competitors don’t see:

- **Manage buttons** on the surfaces you can author — most importantly Manage challenges on the challenges page.
- **Drafts** — unpublished challenges are visible to you everywhere, labelled, and invisible to competitors.
- **The status-gate bypass** — before the competition starts (and after it ends) competitors see a closed notice, while you keep full access to build, test, and review. While the event is paused, competitors can’t submit but you still can, so you can verify a fix live.

Your home: the dashboard

The dashboard provides a comprehensive operational overview for the competition. It features a top navigation bar with a 'New announcement' button and a 'Customize' button. The main content area is divided into several sections:

- Dashboard Overview:** Displays key statistics in a grid of four cards: Solves (6), Submissions (6), Active participants (3), and Published challenges (15).
- Recent activity:** A list of the latest solves across the competition, including the solver's name, the challenge name, the score, and the time ago (5d ago).
- Announcements:** A section for announcements, currently showing 'No announcements yet.'
- Challenge health:** A table showing the status of challenges, including the number of solves and attempts.
- Support queue:** A section for support tickets, currently showing '0 open'.

Dashboard			
Flagpost Demo CTF · operational overview			
Customize			
Solves	Submissions	Active participants	Published challenges
6	6	3	15

Recent activity	
Latest solves across the competition	
bob solved Quick Quiz +50	5d ago
participant solved Quick Quiz +50	5d ago
participant solved Inspect the Source +100	5d ago
alice solved Strings Attached +150	5d ago
alice solved Base What? +150	5d ago
alice solved Inspect the Source +100	5d ago

Challenge health	
Solves vs. attempts	
Inspect the Source	2 solved · 2 tries
Little Bobby Tables	0 solved · 0 tries

Support queue	
0 open	
No open tickets. Support	

The operational overview: solve/submission counters, live activity, challenge health (solves vs. attempts), the announcement composer, and the support queue.

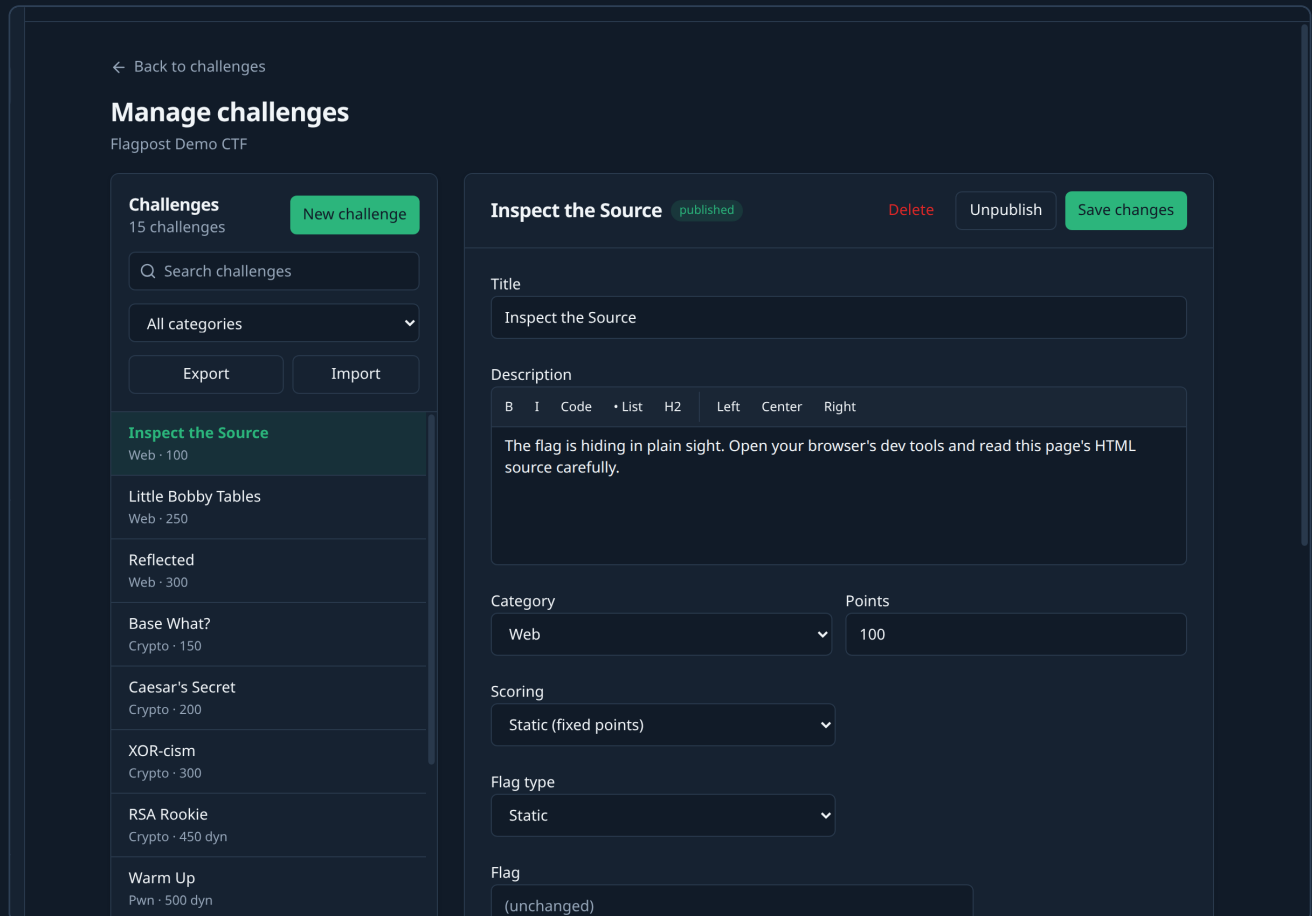
The dashboard is the place to leave open while the event runs — every widget updates live, and **Customize** lets you arrange it to taste. The rest of this guide walks the three phases it fronts: building the event, running it, and supporting the people playing it.

CUSTOM ROLES

Your role may be narrower than the classic Judge — permissions are granular (challenge editing, schedule control, tickets, announcements are all separate grants). If a surface in this guide is missing for you, ask your administrator which grants your role carries.

Authoring challenges

Open **Manage challenges** from the challenges page to reach the authoring surface: your challenge list on the left, the editor for the selected challenge on the right.



The list pane searches and filters, and carries New / Import / Export; the editor keeps Save, Publish and Delete together above the fields.

The lifecycle: draft → published

New challenges are **drafts** — invisible to competitors, so you can build openly during the event. Publishing requires a flag to be set. Unpublishing hides a challenge again without deleting anything; deleting removes it and its attachments, hints, and solve history.

What a challenge can carry

- **Flag types** — **static** (exact match, optionally case-insensitive), **regex** (pattern-graded), or **multiple choice** (options with one correct answer; pairs with guess caps).
- **Scoring** — static points, or **dynamic**: the value decays from a starting value toward a floor as solves accumulate. Every solver holds the current value.
- **Prerequisites** — an unlock chain: competitors must solve the listed challenges first.

- **Release schedule** — a published challenge can stay hidden until a set time, for mid-event waves that need no one awake to push a button.
- **Connection info** — where the live target runs (`nc host 1337` , a URL); shown with a copy button once unlocked.
- **Attachments and hints** — hints can be free or cost points, and can be authored hidden with their own release time.

The flag itself is **write-only**: the editor shows that one is set, never its value — so a shared screen never leaks it.

Categories, difficulty & tags

The **Challenges tab in Settings** owns the vocabulary: categories (the chips competitors filter by), difficulty tiers, and topic tags. Set them early — consistent tagging is what makes a 40-challenge board navigable.

Import & export

Export downloads the whole set as a ctfcli-format zip; **Import** loads one. That's the path for versioning challenges in git, moving an event between instances, or bulk-authoring outside the browser.

Configuring & running the event

Everything about the competition itself lives in **Settings**, organised in tabs.

Settings
Flagpost Demo CTF

General Controls Challenges Rules Assistant Certificates Reports Modules

Name
Flagpost Demo CTF

Description
A sample competition — explore challenges, the scoreboard, support tickets, automations, and more.

Participation mode
Individual

Visibility
Public

PUBLIC STANDINGS

☒ **Public scoreboard** (lists this competition on /public and lets anyone view the board without an account)

☐ **CTFtime scoreboard feed** (exposes a CTFtime-format feed so the event can be rated on ctftime.org)

Brackets / divisions
Parallel rankings competitors self-select (e.g. Students, Open). Leave empty for a single ranking.

Add a bracket... Add

Save changes

Powered by Flagpost

General holds identity and visibility; Controls holds the schedule and the levers you'll pull mid-event; the remaining tabs hold challenge vocabulary, rules, and optional feature panels.

Before the event

- **General** — name, description, individual vs team mode, visibility, and **brackets/divisions** (parallel rankings competitors self-select, e.g. Students and Open). A **public scoreboard** checkbox lists the event on the site's spectator page; a **CTFtime feed** checkbox exposes the standings format ctftime.org rates events from.
- **Rules** — the rules & code of conduct competitors must accept before playing. Change them mid-event and everyone is re-prompted before they can continue.
- **Modules** — per-competition toggles for optional features (automations, feedback, analytics, certificates, reports, AI assistant).

The status gate

A competition is **not started** → **running** → **ended**. Competitors can only open challenges and submit while it's running — before and after they see a closed notice, while staff retain full access. The

schedule can drive the transitions automatically, and **Start/Stop** in Controls override it manually at any moment.

Mid-event levers (Controls)

- **Pause** — freezes submissions during an incident, with a banner for everyone. Staff can still submit, so you can verify the fix before resuming.
- **Scoreboard freeze** — stop public standings updates near the finale. Solves keep counting; reveal the final board when you're ready.
- **Guess caps & wrong-answer penalty** — competition-wide limits for multiple-choice challenges, and an optional percentage each wrong guess shaves off that question's value for that team.

DRY-RUN BEFORE DOORS OPEN

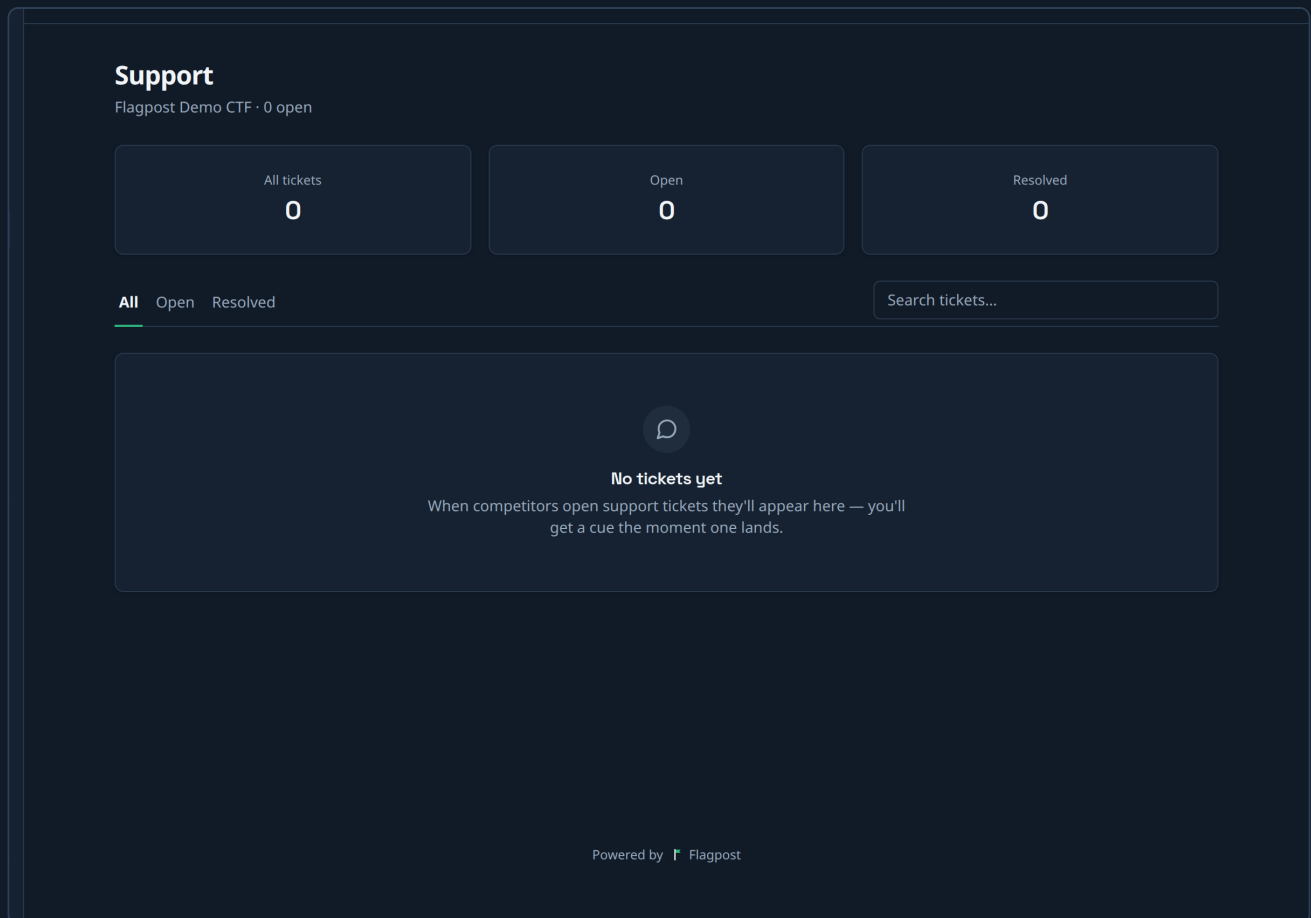
While the competition is not started, play your own board: open every challenge, download every attachment, submit every flag. Ten minutes of staff dry-run catches most day-one tickets.

Supporting competitors

Announcements

New announcement on the dashboard broadcasts to everyone in the competition — it lands live as a banner on every open session and stays in the feed. Use it for challenge waves, hint drops, schedule changes, and incident notices. Announce before competitors notice, not after the tickets arrive.

The support queue



Tickets are live conversations — replies stream in real time on both sides, and competitors are notified when you answer.

Competitor tickets arrive in **Support**, with the open count on your dashboard’s queue widget. Working principles that keep a queue healthy:

- **Acknowledge fast, resolve second** — a one-line “looking into it” stops the duplicate tickets and the hallway anxiety.
- **Reproduce before you rule** — “the flag won’t submit” is a claim; paste it yourself before answering. You can submit even while paused.
- If a challenge really is broken, **pause or unpublish it**, announce, fix, and consider the scoring impact before resuming.
- Close resolved tickets so the queue reflects reality.

Guess resets

Multiple-choice challenges cap guesses. When a competitor exhausts theirs for a legitimate reason (a broken hint, an ambiguous option you've since fixed), open the challenge in the editor: its **Guesses** section resets attempts for one team/competitor or for everyone — history is kept, so nothing is destroyed.

FAIRNESS TRAVELS IN PAIRS

Anything you grant one team — a reset, a nudge, extra time on a target — be prepared to grant every team in the same situation. The audit log records staff actions, and post-event write-ups read better when the answer to “why them?” is “same as everyone”.

Watching the event

Reading the room

The dashboard's widgets are your event telemetry:

- **Challenge health** — solves vs. attempts per challenge. Many attempts and no solves can mean good and hard — or broken. Zero attempts usually means nobody's found the entry point (or the description undersells it).
- **Recent activity** — the live solve stream. A sudden burst on one challenge right after a hint tells you the hint priced correctly; a first-blood minutes after release tells you it didn't.
- **Support queue** — open count trending up is the earliest warning you have an infrastructure or clarity problem.

Optional instrumentation

If the modules are enabled for your competition (Settings → Modules):

- **Analytics** — solve funnels, category breakdowns, and activity over time on the Analytics page.
- **Feedback** — competitors rate challenges after solving; aggregate ratings per challenge show which ones earned their points.
- **Automations** — event-driven rules (announce on first blood, notify a webhook on solve spikes, release a hint at a time) via the visual builder on the Automations page.
- **Certificates and Reports** — panels in Settings for participation certificates and the post-event report.

Closing out

When the schedule ends (or you press Stop), submissions close and the board settles. If you froze the scoreboard, reveal it at your ceremony. Export the challenge set for next year, skim the feedback ratings while memories are fresh, and hand the platform-level wrap-up — archiving the competition, certificates at scale, backups — to your administrator.

The deeper operational reference — deployment, scaling, integrations — lives at docs.flagpost.io.

FAQ

What do competitors see of a draft?

Nothing — no card, no count, no scoreboard trace. Drafts (including unpublished-again challenges) exist only for staff, so you can build and repair openly during a live event.

I edited a live challenge — what happens to points already scored?

Description, connection info, hints and attachments apply immediately. Point values: on a **static** challenge, existing solves keep the value they scored and future solves earn the new one; on a **dynamic** challenge the platform already re-values every solver as the decay moves. If a mistake cost teams points, compensate with an **award** rather than retro-editing values.

Can I grant bonus points?

Yes — **awards**: titled, point-bearing recognition granted to a team or competitor (write-up prizes, sportsmanship, compensation for a broken target). They fold into the scoreboard like any other points and need the `score_override` permission.

A team legitimately burned all their guesses. Now what?

Open the challenge in the editor — its **Guesses** section restores attempts for one team/competitor or for everyone. History is kept, so the reset is visible and non-destructive.

Pause or stop — which do I want?

Pause for incidents: submissions close, everyone sees the banner, the schedule keeps its dates, and staff can still submit to verify a fix. **Stop** ends gameplay. If an incident ate meaningful time, pause, fix, then extend the end time in Controls before resuming.

When can I safely test challenges myself?

Before the start and while paused — competitors are gated then, but staff submissions work, so you can run the whole board end-to-end. Make the dry-run a ritual: every attachment downloads, every target answers, every flag submits.

Import said it skipped some challenges.

The importer reports created / skipped / errors per run: challenges that already exist are **skipped**, **never overwritten**, and per-file errors name the offending entry. Fix the named entries and re-import — the already- created ones simply skip.